an aircraft dedicated to round-the-clock transport in the event of an attack. The only plane available that night was a Russian transport carrier located 165 miles north of Delhi. Additional time was lost because the pilot needed to be woken, the crew assembled and the plane fueled before it could even take off. By the time it arrived in Delhi to take the NSG to Mumbai it was already 02:00. Despite the fact that a commercial flight takes 2 hours from Delhi to Mumbai, the NSG transport took 3.5 hours.[53]

Most counter-terrorism experts assert that a rapid-reaction force must be on site within thirty minutes. The NSG arrived almost a full twelve hours after the first shots were fired. It was almost another hour before they were able to begin search-and-rescue activities. By the time they engaged, most of the hostages who were killed at the two hotels and the Chabad House had been dead for hours.[54] The standoff, however, continued. This owed in part to poor operational planning. Despite all of the time it took the NSG commandos to travel to Mumbai, they reportedly were never informed at any point during the trip that two hotels were under attack. The commandos arrived believing it was only one. Nor were they told that the floors at the Oberoi encircled an atrium, enabling the terrorists to assume vantage points on higher floors and fire on those entering the building. Yet the Mumbai police, army and Marcos were all on the ground and so could have transmitted this information to the NSG commandos in advance of their arrival.[55] The army had even established an operations hub, which should have facilitated information sharing, but it was never converted into a joint operations center. Nor did the NSG set up an operational command center of its own to coordinate the rescue mission, leaving commandos to storm the hotels without adequate real-time intelligence. Inadequate equipment also constrained their operational choices, as the lack of night vision goggles and thermal-imaging systems meant they could only operate during daylight hours.[56] The NSG commandos charged with securing the Taj also had only one electronic-swipe master key, and it took NSG teams up to five minutes to open or force there way into each room.[57]

Before they could even begin an assault on the Chabad House surrounding buildings had to be cleared. The NSG did not have the authority to do this and so the Mumbai Police were called in. Local residents opened their homes to those being temporarily displaced, but the process took almost an entire day.[58] When operations did begin at the